

## First: The Vanga Lineage — Why Kabir Singh Matters

Your professor's opening point — "*the same director made Kabir Singh*" — is not just biographical context. It's the analytical frame. Vanga has made essentially the same film three times in escalating intensity: Arjun Reddy (2017, Telugu) → Kabir Singh (2019, Hindi remake) → Animal (2023). Each iteration takes the previous film's most controversial elements and amplifies them.

Arjun Reddy, Kabir Singh, and Animal all sparked heightened criticism for the depiction of toxic masculinity and justifying violence in relationships as a sign of passion. Animal showed even more intensity and violence than its predecessor, Kabir Singh. [Wpmucdn](#)

What this lineage tells you: Animal is not an accident or an outlier. It is the logical conclusion of a director who has been systematically testing how far audiences will follow a monstrous protagonist if you make him sympathetic enough. Each film asks: how much will you forgive this man? And each time, audiences largely said yes — at the box office, if not in critical reception.

The key escalation from Kabir Singh to Animal: Kabir Singh's violence was personal and self-destructive — he destroyed himself. Rannvijay's violence in Animal is *outward and triumphant*. He survives. He wins. The film doesn't punish him. That absence of consequence is the ideological statement.

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### 1. The Masculinity Being Portrayed — Macho, Dominant, Violent

Hindi cinema showcases male characters who embody traits of dominance, strength, and assertiveness, often at the expense of female characters. These portrayals, often termed the "alpha male" archetype, depict men as the epitome of masculinity, who have very little emotion and are not at all sensitive. The alpha male characters are typically shown as successful, powerful, and commanding, garnering respect and admiration from other characters. [WikiBio](#)

Rannvijay (Ranbir Kapoor) is the fullest expression of this archetype in contemporary Bollywood. But what makes him specifically interesting for your course is how the film constructs his violence. It is never random — it is always in service of protection or revenge. He protects his father, his family, his bloodline. The violence is framed as love expressed through the only language he knows.

At its core, the story revolves around Rannvijay, whose character is consumed by an insatiable hunger for his father's approval and affection. This sets the stage for a toxic journey fraught with internal and external conflict. Balbir's indifference and dismissive attitude towards his son serve as catalysts for Rannvijay's descent into a dark and toxic world of violence and chaos. [WikiBio](#)

This is crucial: the violence has a psychological origin. Rannvijay is not violent because he's evil — he's violent because he was emotionally abandoned by the one man whose approval defined him. The film uses this origin to ask you to understand, if not excuse, everything that follows. That move — giving the monster a wound — is what makes the film controversial rather than simply bad.

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### 2. Alpha Male vs Beta Male — The Film's Structural Argument

Your professor identified this correctly and it's central. The film is built on a binary that it never questions: there are Alpha men and Beta men, and the film's entire moral universe is organised around this distinction.

The *Beta male* in the film is most clearly embodied by Geetanjali's original fiancé — a decent, stable, conventionally responsible man who dies and whose heart is literally transplanted into Rannvijay. This is the film's most pointed metaphor: the Beta man literally gives his heart so the Alpha can live. He is not a villain. He is simply *lesser* in the film's logic, and his function is to be surpassed and replaced.

Animal celebrates the virtues of rage, domination and repression, stripping women off their personality and turning them into mere submissive tools. These perceptions assist in perpetuating negative gender roles and shape social perceptions. [Cambridge Core](#)

The Alpha/Beta binary also maps onto the father-son dynamic. Balbir Singh (Anil Kapoor) is himself an Alpha — successful, powerful, emotionally withholding. Rannvijay's entire psychology is the desire to be *seen* as his equal or successor. The film frames this as the most primal masculine drive: the son wanting the father's recognition of his power. *Beta men* — sensitive, reasonable, domestically stable — simply *don't register* in this universe as *worthy of the father's gaze*.

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### 3. The Docile Feminine — Built to Serve the Alpha

Your professor's point about the "*more docile version of the feminine character*" introduced to enforce the Alpha masculinity is a textbook application of what Connell calls **emphasised femininity** — the femininity constructed specifically to complement hegemonic masculinity.

Geetanjali (Rashmika Mandanna) is docile, forgiving, beautiful, domestic and endlessly patient. She knows Rannvijay is violent, unfaithful, and obsessive. She stays. The film *doesn't* present this as tragedy — it presents it as love. *Her submission is the proof of his desirability.*

Geetanjali's character is caught between devotion and endurance. Her love for Vijay often reads less like romance and more like sacrifice. At times, she becomes the emotional anchor of the film — holding together a family threatened by violence and obsession. *She was drawn by the "Alpha male" story he had told her on the roof of her father's house immediately after her engagement.*

[Letterboxd](#)

Notice the timing there — *she abandons her fiancé immediately after hearing Rannvijay's self-mythologising*. She doesn't fall for him despite his darkness; she falls for him *because* of the Alpha narrative he constructs for himself. The film is arguing that *this kind of woman exists and makes this choice freely*. That is part of its ideology — it isn't forcing Geetanjali, it's showing her choosing. *Which makes the choice itself the statement.*

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### 4. Is the Film Glorifying or Critiquing? — Your Professor's Most Important Question

This is the question your professor raised — *"is the film actually saying this type of masculinity leads to nowhere?"* — and it's the sharpest critical question you can ask about Animal. The honest answer is: **the film is genuinely ambiguous, and that ambiguity is probably deliberate.**

**The case that it glorifies:** The cinematography treats Rannvijay as a god. Slow-motion violence in golden light. A 3.5-hour runtime that refuses to cut him down. He survives assassination. He wins every fight. His wife stays. His father finally embraces him. *There are no consequences that stick*. The alpha male characters are a *classic symbol of heroism, and their dominating behavior is loved and applauded*, making them a big hit at the box office. [WikiBio](#)

**The case that it critiques:** Although the emotional foundation of the father-son relationship appeals to viewers, the way this tie is framed through violence begs the issue of what social ideals are being upheld. Rannvijay's relationships are all hollow. His marriage to Geetanjali is possessive, not loving. His relationship with Zoya is purely transactional. His only real emotional connection — his father — is defined by a wound that never heals. The film shows a man with everything (wealth, power, women, revenge) who is fundamentally alone and emotionally stunted. You could read that as a critique: *this is what this masculinity actually gets you*. [YouTube](#)

**The honest position:** The film depicts the critique but doesn't commit to it. It shows Rannvijay's isolation without condemning it, shows the hollowness of his relationships without mourning them, and ends without punishing him. A committed critique would make the audience feel the cost. Animal makes the audience feel the thrill and leaves the cost as a footnote. The ambiguity serves the box office — men who want to celebrate Rannvijay can, and critics who want to condemn the film can find evidence for their reading too.

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## 5. Men Threatened by Social Change — The Protest Masculinity Argument

This is the most academically sophisticated point in your professor's notes and it maps directly onto Connell's theory of protest masculinity.

The argument: in an era of shifting gender roles, rising feminism, and women's increasing economic and social power, some men experience this as a threat to their identity and status. The response is not to adapt but to double down — to perform hypermasculinity more aggressively as a defensive assertion of the old order.

Films like Animal have sparked debates about the portrayal of gender dynamics in Bollywood, highlighting both progress and areas for improvement. Despite some progress with films showcasing empowered female characters, the industry still predominantly glorifies masculinity and objectifies women. [WikiBio](#)

Animal's massive commercial success in 2023 — the same year that globally saw significant feminist discourse — is not a coincidence. It arrived as a backlash text. Its audience, significantly male, responded to a film that said: *forget all this talk of sensitivity and emotional availability. This is what a real man is*. The film's success is the backlash made visible.

Connect this to DDLJ: in 1995, the threat to masculinity was westernisation — Raj had to prove he was Indian enough. In 2023, the threat is feminism and social change — Rannvijay has to prove he is man enough. Different historical anxieties, same defensive structure.

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## 6. The Father-Son Relationship as the Real Love Story

Your professor identified this precisely. The most passionate, most emotionally raw, most cinematically indulged relationship in the film is not between Rannvijay and Geetanjali — it is between Rannvijay and Balbir.

At its core, Animal is less about plot twists and more about emotions — particularly the raw, complicated bond between father and son. Ranbir Kapoor plays Vijay Singh, a man whose entire existence is defined by his desperate longing for his father's approval. [Letterboxd](#)

Every act of violence in the film is ultimately an act of devotion to the father. Rannvijay kills for Balbir. He rebuilds himself for Balbir. He survives a transplant of another man's heart — and still the complex equation with his father is unchanged. The film's emotional climax is not the romantic resolution but the moment the father finally sees the son.

This has a specific implication for the film's gender politics: women in the film are structurally incapable of being the primary love object because the primary love object is male. The film is, at its emotional core, a story about men and patrilineal succession — the bloodline must be preserved, the father must be honoured, the son must be validated. Women are the means through which the bloodline continues. They are not the point.

This also explains the infidelity. Zoya (Triptii Dimri) is not a romantic rival to Geetanjali — she is functionally a reproductive and status instrument. The film doesn't treat the infidelity as a betrayal of love because love in this film flows vertically (father to son) not horizontally (husband to wife).

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## 7. Wife as Possession, Other Woman as Tool — and They Know

Your professor's sharpest observation: *"the women know and acknowledge this."*

Geetanjali as possession: she is introduced through Rannvijay's gaze, claimed immediately, and her arc is entirely defined by her relationship to him. She has no ambitions, no career, no interiority outside of him. She represents the extension of the Alpha's domain into the domestic sphere. When Rannvijay plays her the audio of their first night together — one of the film's most discussed scenes — she smiles. The film presents her consent to her own objectification as the final proof of his desirability.

Zoya as tool: she was drawn by the "Alpha male" story he had told her on the roof of her father's house immediately after her engagement. She is not deceived. She chooses him knowing exactly what he is. This is the film's most cynical ideological move — by making both women choose consciously, it removes any possibility of the audience reading them as victims. The film insulates itself from the charge of depicting victimisation by ensuring the women are always shown as consenting participants. [Letterboxd](#)

This is more sophisticated than simple objectification. It's the film arguing: *women want this*. Which is far more ideologically potent and dangerous than simply showing a man dominate.

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## 8. Infidelity Justified — What Makes This Unusual

Your professor noted this is uncommon in Bollywood, and they're right. Hindi cinema has a long tradition of treating female infidelity as moral catastrophe while treating male infidelity as a complexity to be resolved. But even male infidelity is usually framed with guilt, consequence, or at minimum an acknowledgement that it's wrong.

Animal removes even that minimal acknowledgement. The normalization of cheating within the narrative was a point of contention for some viewers, who found it morally questionable. Rannvijay's relationship with Zoya is not presented as a weakness or a fall — it's presented as an expression of his nature. Alpha men, the film implies, cannot and should not be confined by monogamy. The bloodline logic makes this explicit: he needs multiple women to ensure the continuation of his

lineage. Geetanjali is the legitimate wife; Zoya is a secondary attachment. The film borrows from an almost feudal logic of masculine entitlement. [WikiBio](#)

The reason this is so unusual: it challenges the one romantic standard that even the most patriarchal Bollywood films usually maintain — that the hero *loves* the heroine exclusively, even if he controls her. Animal removes even that. Rannvijay doesn't love Geetanjali in any recognisable romantic sense. He possesses her.